PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Mercedes-Benz G 550

2009–2018 (US) · W463 · M273 5.5 V8 · M176 4.0 TT V8

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Decide on the engine first**
  2009–2015 trucks have the naturally aspirated 5.5-litre M273; 2016–2018 trucks have the 4.0-litre twin-turbo M176. Same chassis, same lockers, different maintenance profile — and the 2016-on trucks command more money.
- [ ] **Test all three lockers**
  Engage centre, rear and front in order on a loose surface and watch the dash indicators. A truck whose lockers ‘were never used’ often has a vacuum or actuation fault waiting.
- [ ] **Watch the temperature gauge (M273)**
  A slow-to-warm or erratic coolant temperature, or codes P0597–P0599, points at the map-controlled thermostat — the most common M273 failure.
- [ ] **Scan for swirl-flap codes (M273)**
  P2004, P2005 or P2006 mean the intake-manifold flap mechanism has failed. Don’t ignore it: broken flap pieces can be ingested by the engine.
- [ ] **Look behind the front wheels**
  Gear oil on the inner wheels, calipers or rotors means leaking front axle seals — and possibly contaminated brakes.
- [ ] **Drive it at 55–70 mph**
  Wander, wheel shake or a vague on-centre feel usually means a worn steering damper and tired linkage — common on the solid-axle G.
- [ ] **Rust where nobody cleans**
  Tailgate lower edge, door bottoms, sills, rear frame tubes, strut mounts, inner wheel arches and around the rear bumper. Salt-belt trucks deserve a lift and a flashlight.
- [ ] **Check the headliner and the badges**
  Autocar warns that a sagging headliner can mean water has got in, so check the sunroof drains and seals. And plenty of G 550s wear AMG bumpers and badges — check the VIN before paying a G 63 premium.

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- [ ] **Fuel line quick connectors**
  2009 · NHTSA 09V453
- [ ] **Front turn signals behind grille covers (FMVSS 108)**
  2002–2010 · NHTSA 10V366
- [ ] **Passenger airbag molding strip**
  2011 · NHTSA 12V380

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- [ ] **VIN characters 4–8**
  Bring a Trailer examples decoded with NHTSA's vPIC tool: 2010–2014 G 550 (5.5 V8) = WDCYC3HF..., 2016 G 550 (4.0 twin-turbo) = WDCYC3KF..., 2018 G 550 = WDCYC3KH.... A 2015 G 63 AMG reads WDCYC7DF..., so a 'G 63' with a YC3 VIN is a dressed-up G 550.

- [ ] **Steering coupling**
  2013–2016 · NHTSA 17V250
- [ ] **Inner door-handle release cable**
  2016 · NHTSA 17V178
- [ ] **ESP with DISTRONIC PLUS**
  2016–2017 · NHTSA 17V713
- [ ] **Brake booster vacuum hose**
  2017 · NHTSA 17V817
- [ ] **Emergency-call date/time software**
  2013–2016 · NHTSA 19V787
- [ ] **4×4² versus regular G 550**
  The 2017–2018 G 550 4×4² decodes as WDCYC5FF… / WDCYC5FH…, not YC3. A portal-axle truck without a YC5F VIN is an aftermarket conversion.
- [ ] **Model year (10th character)**
  The 10th character gives the model year (A = 2010, C = 2012, E = 2014, G = 2016, J = 2018). 2009–2015 trucks have the M273 5.5; 2016–2018 have the M176 twin-turbo.
- [ ] **Engine bay**
  The M273 is a naturally aspirated V8; the M176 has twin turbos inside the vee. A quick look settles which engine it is.

NOTES

From the full guide at https://boxytrucks.com/models/g-class/g550/, with sources. Recalls follow the VIN: check at nhtsa.gov/recalls. General information only, not a professional inspection; see boxytrucks.com/about/disclaimer/. © BoxyTrucks